

Sustainable Accountability

45–55 min · October Week 3

★ PPRA — COUNSELOR AWARENESS

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish accountability from self-punishment and apply the four-step accountability structure to a real situation.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management (primary) · Self-Awareness (supporting) · Relationship Skills (supporting)
DURATION	45–55 min · October Week 3
KEY VOCABULARY	accountability · self-punishment · guilt · shame · living amend · four-step accountability · repair
MATERIALS	Journals · Anchor chart · Scenario Cards B4-10A and B4-10B · WS B4-U2-WS2 (Accountability Structure)
OPENING REVIEW	'Last lesson: Not Yet lens. Quick — what is the three-step failure diagnosis?' [Answer.] 'Today: what do you do when the failure is not a bad outcome but something you did that contradicts your values?'

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 9–10 · EARLY HIGH SCHOOL

Goal 3 — Responsible Decision-Making

3A.4a Demonstrate personal responsibility in making ethical decisions.

Goal 1 — Self-Awareness & Self-Management

1A.4b Generate ways to develop more positive attitudes.

Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).

★ PPRA — COUNSELOR AWARENESS REQUIRED

PPRA-designated. Disclosure of personal mistakes and accountability patterns. Standard opt-out protocols. Brief counselor before delivery. Students who describe severe self-punishment in response to minor mistakes — note for counselor before L7. The Friend Test in Step 3 is the

highest-activation moment — journal first.

ANCHOR CHART

ACCOUNTABILITY HONEST
ACKNOWLEDGMENT
GENUINE REPAIR
COMMITMENT TO
DIFFERENT CHOICE MOVE
ON — DO NOT REVISIT
PRODUCES LEARNING

SELF-PUNISHMENT
REPEATING CONDEMNATION
NO REPAIR — JUST
SUFFERING NO
COMMITMENT — JUST
GUILT CANNOT MOVE ON
PRODUCES SHAME, NOT
LEARNING

OPENING RITUAL

60–90 seconds 'Both feet on the floor. One breath slower than usual.' [Pause 10 seconds.] 'When you make a mistake — not a failure of capacity, but a choice that contradicted your values — how long do you typically spend feeling bad about it versus actually fixing it? Today we look at the difference between those two things. One produces something. One produces nothing.' [Post: 'What is the difference between holding yourself accountable and punishing yourself?']

NOTE

REGULATION & REPAIR STRAND: ACCOUNTABILITY WITHOUT COLLAPSE — THE THREE-PART CHECK · Touchpoint 2 of 5 PLACEMENT: Embed immediately after Step 2 — at the moment students have learned the four-step structure but before they apply it to their own situation. TIME: 6–8 minutes. Protected — do not cut for time. STEP A — NAME THE SKILL (1 min): 'This is called the Accountability Check. A three-part internal practice you use in the exact moment when taking responsibility starts to feel like proof that you are fundamentally broken.' STEP B — EXPLAIN WHY HERE (1 min): 'You have just learned the four-step structure. The reason most people skip Step 4 is that shame pulls them back to Step 0 before they reach it. The Check is how you stay in Steps 1 through 4 without collapsing.' STEP C — TEACH THE THREE-PART CHECK (2 min). Write on board: CHECK A — BEHAVIOR OR BEING? 'I made a choice that caused harm' (accountability) vs. 'I am a person who causes harm' (shame). They feel the same. They are not the same. CHECK B — FORWARD OR INWARD? Pointing FORWARD toward repair = accountability. Pulling INWARD toward self-focus = shame spiral. CHECK C — WHAT IS THE NEXT RIGHT ACTION? Not perfect. Not complete. The next right action. Write it down specifically. STEP D — TEACHER MODELS (1 min): Use a generic example. Narrate all three checks aloud. Do not use a student's example. STEP E — STUDENTS PRACTICE (90 sec): Apply the Check to their Step 2 situation privately in journals. Write the answer to Check C specifically. STEP F — ANCHOR AND POST (30 sec): Post the three checks on the anchor chart next to the Four-Step Accountability Structure. TEACHING TIP: Frame as a cognitive tool: 'Not about feeling better — about staying functional enough to actually fix it.'

Common error: students using Check A to minimize impact before genuinely acknowledging it. Check A is precision, not minimization.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Friend Test in Step 3, a student who gives their friend a genuinely warm, specific, forward-looking response — then appears visibly surprised when asked to say the same thing to themselves.

MAY SIGNAL This student has functional empathy for others but a significant self-compassion deficit. The gap is visible to them in this moment. This is the curriculum working.

ACTION Affirm quietly after class: 'That gap you noticed — that's exactly what this unit is about.' No further intervention needed. This student will be a strong presence through L6. |

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Living Amend step, a student who describes ongoing harm caused to a specific named person with significant detail and activation.

MAY SIGNAL A living amend toward ongoing significant harm may require more than behavioral change commitment — may need counselor support to navigate safely.

ACTION Do not probe during class. After class: 'The situation you were thinking about — if you want to talk it through with someone who can really help, I can connect you with our counselor.' Follow disclosure protocol. |

SCENARIO CARDS · FACILITATION NOTES

B4-10A and B4-10B B4-10A (RYN'S CONFESSION): Whole-class. Key: 'Accountability has four steps. Where is Ryn stuck?' She completed Step 1 but is caught between Step 1 and Step 4 — in self-punishment, not accountability. B4-10B (MARCUS AND THE MONEY): Pairs. Key: 'Design a living amend for Marcus — specific, observable, time-bound.'

GRADE-BAND DIFFERENTIATION

GRADES 9 · 10	GRADES 11 · 12
Grades 9–10: Keep the four-step structure concrete. The Friend Test is the most memorable tool — return to it in L5 and L6. Honor the difficulty: 'It is genuinely hard to hold yourself accountable without punishing yourself, especially	Grades 11–12: 'The living amend is the adult version of accountability. In workplaces and relationships, repeated apologies without behavioral change erode trust faster than the original error. What does it mean to be someone

if punishment was modeled as accountability.'

whose word means something?' Connects directly to B5-U2-L1 (Living Amends).

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between accountability and self-punishment in my own words is _____. One time I punished myself when I could have been accountable is _____. A living amend I owe — rather than another apology — is _____." Journal — private. Never collected. Never graded.

★ PPRA — COUNSELOR AWARENESS REQUIRED

LEGAL / PPRA NOTE ★ PPRA-DESIGNATED. Accountability vs. Self-Punishment reflection and Living Amend prompt. Standard opt-out protocols apply. Students describing severe self-punishment in response to minor mistakes — flag for counselor before L7. Safe messaging guidelines apply throughout Unit 2.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Most important conceptual distinction in Unit 2 outside L6: guilt vs. shame. Guilt = I did something that contradicts my values — repair. Shame = I am someone who contradicts my values — hiding, spiraling, avoidance. Make this distinction explicit. The Living Amend concept is among the most transferable tools in the curriculum — extended significantly in B5-U2-L1. Students who describe significant self-punishment patterns across L1 and L3 are your highest-risk students for L7. Brief counselor on any students fitting this profile before the Backpack Audit.

FAMILY CONNECTION · CONVERSATION STARTER

L3 · ★ PPRA Dear Families, Today students learned the difference between accountability (four-step process producing forward motion) and self-punishment (shame-based suffering that produces nothing useful). They were introduced to the living amend: genuine accountability measured not by the sincerity of an apology but by the consistency of behavioral change over time. Conversation-starter: 'Is there a difference between someone apologizing and someone actually changing? What does actually changing look like to you?'

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · Steps 1 — 4 · read aloud or in your own words

01 THE ACCOUNTABILITY-PUNISHMENT DISTINCTION

7 MIN

'Accountability says: I made a choice that did not fit who I want to be. What do I need to do? Self-punishment says: I am bad. I will suffer.' Point to chart. 'The Internal Critic uses self-punishment to masquerade as conscience — look how bad I feel, that proves I care. But feeling bad is not the same as taking responsibility. Ryn confessed to her teacher — the accountable thing. Then she looped, replaying, catastrophizing, unable to rest. She confused suffering with accountability. They are not the same.'

02 THE FOUR-STEP ACCOUNTABILITY STRUCTURE

8 MIN

Write the four steps on the board as you teach. 'Circle Step 4 — Moving On. Suffering is not on this list. Feeling appropriately bad — yes, that is human and honest. Circling in shame for weeks — no. That is self-punishment masquerading as conscience.' Pairs: 'Name one situation where you held yourself accountable by this standard — all four steps. What happened?' No sharing required.

03 THE FRIEND TEST

8 MIN

'If your best friend came to you and said I did the same thing you just did — what would you say to them? Write that answer first.' [2 min private writing.] 'Now say the same thing to yourself about your own situation. The gap between what you would say to your friend and what you say to yourself is the size of the self-compassion adjustment you are being invited to make.' Distribute WS B4-U2-WS2 (Accountability Structure) — students complete Part 3 (Friend Test) now.

04 THE LIVING AMEND

5 MIN

'An apology is a statement. A living amend is sustained behavioral change over time.' Write: APOLOGY = statement. LIVING AMEND = sustained behavioral change. Students complete Part 4 (Living Amend) of WS B4-U2-WS2. Private. Never shared.

SCENARIO CARDS

Print and laminate before unit. Two cards per lesson.

B 4 - 10 A
NOTE ****SUSTAINABLE ACCOUNTABILITY****** ★ SAFETY****THE SITUATION**

After cheating on a test — a decision she made in a moment of panic and has regretted ever since — Ryn confessed to her teacher. The teacher was disappointed but did not escalate beyond the grade consequence. Ryn expected to feel better after confessing. Instead she found herself looping: replaying the moment, catastrophizing about who she is, unable to let it rest. 'I told the truth,' she said. 'Why can't I move on?'

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Ryn did the accountable thing — she confessed. What is preventing accountability from producing peace? What is the difference between the guilt that motivated Ryn's confession and the shame spiral she is now in? Accountability has four steps: honest acknowledgment, genuine repair, commitment to a different choice, and moving on. Where is Ryn stuck? What would Ryn's Compassionate Witness say to her about the difference between what she did and who she is?

B 4 - 10 B
NOTE ****SUSTAINABLE ACCOUNTABILITY****** ★ SAFETY****THE SITUATION**

Marcus borrowed money from a friend and didn't pay it back when he said he would — three times. Each time, he felt bad, apologized, and promised to do better. His friend eventually said: 'I don't need another apology. I need you to actually pay me back.' Marcus felt attacked. He thought: 'I said I was sorry. What more do they want?'

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What has Marcus confused about what an apology accomplishes? Marcus's friend says they want action, not words. What is the distinction — and is the friend being unfair? What is the difference between a genuine apology and a apology used to relieve the apologizer's discomfort? Design a living amend for Marcus — what would sustained behavioral change actually look like in this situation?

APOLOGY VS. LIVING AMEND

An apology is a statement. A living amend is a sustained behavioral change over time. The distinction matters because repeated apologies without

changed behavior are not accountability — they are a pattern that eventually damages trust more than the original harm. Genuine accountability is measured not by how sincerely you apologize but by how consistently you act differently afterward.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 4 · THE FAÇADE (9–10)

Accountability vs. Self-Punishment

Unit 2

REPAIR

ACCOUNTABILITY

- Honest acknowledgment
- Genuine repair
- Commitment to a different choice
- Move on — do not revisit
- Produces learning

SELF-PUNISHMENT

- Repeating condemnation
- No repair — just suffering
- No commitment — just guilt
- Cannot move on
- Produces shame, not learning

One produces learning. The other produces shame.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 4 · The Façade (9–10)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

architectureofgrace.org